

decision and action. The system has become more athlete-oriented, and the results are there for all to see," she adds.

"Government facilities have played a huge role in pushing para sports. The Sports Authority of India (SAI) and National Centres of Excellence (NCE) have really upped the standards of facilities available for para-athletes, enabling them to train at these venues almost all year round. The absorption of para-athletes in the Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) has also made a huge difference," Jhajharia points out.

"Another significant development is that now Central Government agencies like the Income Tax Department, the Revenue Department, and others have job quotas specifically set aside for para-athletes. In this system, jobs are secured, training facilities are provided, and a sports-conducive environment is created, leaving athletes with nothing to worry about except succeeding. Alone, any one of these elements would have posed challenges for people with disabilities. Therefore, these need to work in tandem.

"Increased funding has been the smallest part of the change. The more important shift, a direct consequence of that funding, has been in the training structures and approach. The map of centres for para-athletes across the country has many more pins now," he adds.

Course correction

Jhajharia remembers funding his own Paralympic dreams for the Athens Games, a memory that takes him back to what he describes as the 'dark ages' of the sport. Unlike today, when athletes returning from international events are greeted with elaborate processions and welcome ceremonies, only Jhajharia's father was waiting for him at the airport when he returned with gold from the Athens Summer Games. The Khel Ratna awardee has not forgotten, and hopes never to forget, the sting of that invisibility.

"My aim has always been to

ensure that the players under me get whatever I didn't. When I started out, I had spikes worth just 300-400 rupees and nothing else. I couldn't afford anything better, yet I broke the world record with those spiked shoes," he says, reflecting on a lonelier time in India's Paralympic history.

Back then, athletes were at the mercy of fate. If they managed to secure funding — often barely enough — their dreams survived, albeit on life support.

Understandably, Jhajharia and Deepa, who came before him, praise the financial autonomy athletes now enjoy with the Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) and increased attention from the Central Government in terms of policy and funding.

"We had 50 athletes under TOPS for Paris, and it not only put money in the hands of the player, but also ensured that an all-round support system could be forged to maximise performance. It gives players a lot of autonomy and puts decision-making back in their hands. They could choose their coaches, decide whether to train in India or abroad, and fine-tune their preparation as they saw fit," Jhajharia explains.

Deepa also reveals that the Government's funding for the Paris campaign exceeded INR 70 crore, a significant jump from the INR 8-10 crore that the PCI used to receive in the past.

Strengthening the SAI centres to include para sports disciplines and improving the NCEs paid rich dividends for the PCI in Paris. The inaugural Khelo India Para Games, held in New Delhi in 2023, also came at an opportune time for the Federation. Sixteen athletes from that event went on to compete in the Paris Games.

Hand-in-hand

The onus of supporting para-athletes is no longer just a Central Government issue. One of the mandates for the PCI has been to ensure greater participation from state federations, which has, in turn, helped the national body streamline

scouting better than ever before.

While state-level administrations play a key role in widening the talent pool, their primary contribution so far has been injecting booster funds into an athlete's training cycle. The Tamil Nadu government's support for Mariyappan is a case in point.

In 2016, when Mariyappan returned as the Paralympic champion in the men's high jump T42 category, the then-Chief Minister J. Jayalalithaa announced a cash reward of INR 2 crore, putting him on par with able-bodied gold medallists from the state.

Eight years later, the political party in power has changed, but the support for the high jumper remains steadfast.

"Before the Paralympics, the TN government sanctioned an amount of INR 7 lakh towards my preparation and training. For a long time, it was very difficult to get the amount assured to us for winning medals at the national and international level. But the government ensured para-athletes received their money before the next order of business was taken up," Mariyappan says.

Another key stakeholder in this ecosystem has been non-profits like Olympic Gold Quest and the GoSports Foundation, who have chipped in with funding assistance, and more importantly, accentuated athlete performances by assembling competent and international-standard support staff for the Indians.

Nandan Kamath, co-founder and Managing Trustee of the GoSports Foundation, traces his organisation's involvement in para sports back to the 2010 Commonwealth Games when they worked with the likes of swimmer Sharad Gaikwad. Supporting para-athletes was a natural progression for the foundation, which prioritises nation-building through sports. This ambition was further aided by government legislation in 2013.

Just like in 2016, the heartbreak of the Summer Olympics campaign was eased by the Paralympics triumphs. In Rio, only wrestler Sakshi Malik and